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A GLORIOUS ENGLISH SUMMER

Within a week of returning from South Africa we faced Nasser Hussain's Englishmen at home in December 2001. Nasser, nowadays a respected commentator, played hard and came up with some ultra-defensive tactics against me. It was in this series that Nasser instructed his left-arm spinner Ashley Giles to bowl from over the wicket and consistently pitch the ball way outside my leg stump. Nasser and Giles were counting on the fact that I would have limited scoring options off balls bowled there and were hoping to frustrate me and induce me to play a false shot. They had essentially given up any attempt to get me out in favour of trying to get under my skin.

While Giles did manage to have me stumped, for the first time in my Test career, in the third Test in Bangalore, overall these tactics had little impact on the result of the series. I scored a lot of runs in all three Test matches and was declared Player of the Series.

I was reminded of this series when Nasser, who is a good friend, met me a couple of years later in South Africa during the 2003 World Cup. We were in the washroom during the inaugural function and Nasser jokingly started the conversation, saying, 'So I am in the washroom with the great Mr Tendulkar.' It was a minute-long conversation and we were both enjoying ourselves. It was friendly banter between two people who have great regard for each other. From memory, the conversation went something like this:

NASSER: You have to agree that I was successful in stopping you and getting you frustrated during the 2001 England tour of India when I got Ashley Giles to bowl to you from over the wicket.